

One Flesh, One Bride

What Scripture Really Says About Polygamy

A Teaching Study on Genesis 2:24 and Matthew 19:4-8

Scripture quoted from the World English Bible (WEB), divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai, with Yahshua and Messiah in place of Jesus and Christ. Torah is referred to throughout as the instructions of YHWH.

THE HEART OF IT

Abraham, Jacob, David, and Solomon all had more than one wife, and some people conclude that YHWH must be fine with it. Scripture tells a different story. It records polygamy honestly, regulates it, and then shows us what it did to every household whose story it tells in detail.

What YHWH regulates is not always what YHWH designed. His design has been one man and one woman from the garden, and it points to one Bridegroom and His one bride.

HOW THIS STUDY WORKS

We start with the design, then look at how the instructions handle polygamy, then walk through the households Scripture lets us see, then answer the hard verses head on. Where Scripture does not say something in so many words, this study says so plainly. Each section closes with questions for reflection or discussion.

SECTION I

The Design

Therefore a man will leave his father and his mother, and will join with his wife, and they will be one flesh.

GENESIS 2:24

The Hebrew is *ishto*, "his wife," singular. "Join" is *dabaq* (H1692), to cling, to be glued together. One man leaves, one man clings, to one woman, and the two become one flesh. Adam was not given a second Eve, and Noah took one wife into the ark, as did each of his three sons (Genesis 7:13).

When the Pharisees tested Yahshua about marriage, He did not start with Abraham or David. He went back to Eden:

He answered, Haven't you read that he who made them from the beginning made them male and female, and said, For this cause a man shall leave his father and mother, and shall be joined to his wife; and the two shall become one flesh?' So that they are no more two, but one flesh. What therefore Elohim has joined together, don't let man tear apart.

MATTHEW 19:4-6

In Matthew's Greek, Yahshua quotes the verse as "the two shall become one flesh," the same wording found in the Greek translation of Genesis. Then He adds His own commentary: "they are no more two, but one flesh." The number in the design is two becoming one.

For Reflection

- Why do you think Yahshua answered a question about marriage by going back to the beginning?
- What does "the two shall become one" leave room for, and what does it not?

SECTION II

Regulated Is Not Designed

In the same conversation, the Pharisees asked why Moses allowed divorce. Yahshua's answer gives us a principle:

He said to them, Moses, because of the hardness of your hearts, allowed you to divorce your wives, but from the beginning it has not been so.

MATTHEW 19:8

Yahshua was answering a question about divorce there, not polygamy. But He showed that YHWH sometimes gave instructions to limit the damage of hard hearts, and that those instructions do not overrule the design "from the beginning." The instructions about polygamy fit that pattern.

If he takes another wife to himself, he shall not diminish her food, her clothing, and her marital rights.

EXODUS 21:10

This protects the first wife. A man who takes another wife may not cut her food, her clothing, or her marital rights.

If a man has two wives, the one beloved and the other hated, and they have borne him children, both the beloved and the hated, and if the firstborn son is hers who was hated,

DEUTERONOMY 21:15

This protects the firstborn son of the wife who is not loved. Look at what the instruction assumes: in a house with two wives, one ends up loved, *ahav* (H157), and the other hated, *sane* (H8130). The instruction does not bless the arrangement. It puts a guardrail on the damage.

YHWH also set limits:

You shall not take a wife in addition to her sister, to be a rival, to uncover her nakedness, while her sister is still alive.

LEVITICUS 18:18

He shall not multiply wives to himself, that his heart not turn away. He shall not greatly multiply to himself silver and gold.

DEUTERONOMY 17:17

WHERE SCRIPTURE STOPS

There is no verse in the instructions that says, in so many words, "a man shall have only one wife." Honesty requires saying that. The case against polygamy rests on the design in Genesis 2, Yahshua's appeal to "the beginning," the way the instructions treat it as damage to be limited, the record of every household Scripture shows us, and the standard the Apostles set. Taken together, that is a strong case, and it is the one this study makes.

For Reflection

- Can you think of other things YHWH regulated that He never called good?
- Why would Deuteronomy assume one wife will be "hated"?

SECTION III

The Hebrew Word for a Second Wife

The word "rival" in Leviticus 18:18 is *tsarar* (H6887), to vex, to show hostility, to be an adversary. From that same root comes *tsarah*, the word Scripture uses for a co-wife. It is spelled exactly like *tsarah* (H6869), the ordinary word for trouble and distress.

You can see it in Hannah's story. Elkanah had two wives, Hannah and Peninnah, and Peninnah had children while Hannah had none:

Her rival provoked her severely, to irritate her, because YHWH had shut up her womb.

1 SAMUEL 1:6

"Her rival" is *tsaratah*, her co-wife. It went on year after year, until Hannah wept and would not eat (1 Samuel 1:7).

KEY POINT

The Hebrew language itself tells you what a second wife brings into a home. **The word for her is spelled the same as the word for trouble.**

For Reflection

- What does it tell you that the language of Scripture has a word for a rival wife at all?

SECTION IV

The Track Record

Scripture does not hide the lives of its heroes. It shows us what happened in their homes. Here is every household with multiple wives whose story it tells in any detail.

Lamech

The first man recorded with two wives was Lamech, of the line of Cain (Genesis 4:19). His next recorded words are a boast to both wives that he killed a man for wounding him (Genesis 4:23). That is where polygamy enters the story.

Abraham

Sarai gave Hagar to Abram "to be his wife" (Genesis 16:3). As soon as Hagar conceived, she despised Sarai. Sarai blamed Abram, dealt harshly with Hagar, and Hagar ran into the wilderness (Genesis 16:4-6). The rivalry carried into the next generation with Ishmael and Isaac (Genesis 21:9-10).

Esau

When Esau was forty years old, he took as wife Judith, the daughter of Beeri the Hittite, and Basemath, the daughter of Elon the Hittite. They grieved Isaac's and Rebekah's spirits.

GENESIS 26:34-35

Jacob

Leah, Rachel, Bilhah, and Zilpah turned his tents into a competition. "Rachel envied her sister" (Genesis 30:1). When Bilhah bore a son, Rachel named him Naphtali and said she had wrestled with her sister and prevailed (Genesis 30:8). Jacob loved Rachel's son Joseph more than the others, and the sons of the other mothers hated Joseph and sold him into slavery (Genesis 37:3-4, 28).

Elkanah

Peninnah provoked Hannah year after year (1 Samuel 1:6-7), as we saw above.

Gideon

Gideon had seventy sons conceived from his body, for he had many wives. His concubine who was in Shechem also bore him a son, and he named him Abimelech.

JUDGES 8:30-31

After Gideon died, Abimelech, the son of the concubine, killed his brothers, seventy persons, on one stone. Only Jotham, the youngest, escaped by hiding (Judges 9:5).

David

David took wife after wife, and six sons were born to him in Hebron by six different wives (2 Samuel 3:2-5). His children from different mothers tore his house apart. Amnon violated his half sister Tamar. Her full brother Absalom killed Amnon, then rose up against his own father, and went in to his father's concubines on the roof in the sight of all Israel (2 Samuel 13; 15; 16:22). Later Adonijah, son of yet another wife, tried to seize the throne (1 Kings 1:5).

Solomon

He had seven hundred wives, princesses, and three hundred concubines. His wives turned his heart away. When Solomon was old, his wives turned away his heart after other gods; and his heart was not perfect with YHWH his Elohim, as the heart of David his father was.

1 KINGS 11:3-4

Solomon broke Deuteronomy 17:17 to the letter, and it happened exactly as the instruction warned: his heart turned away. YHWH told him the kingdom would be torn from his house (1 Kings 11:11).

BEING FAIR TO THE TEXT

Scripture also names men such as Ashhur (1 Chronicles 4:5) and Caleb (1 Chronicles 2:18-19, 46-48) with more than one wife or concubine, and tells us nothing about their homes. So the honest claim is not that every polygamist suffered for it. **It is that every time Scripture lets us see inside such a house, we find jealousy, rivalry, favoritism, and broken children, and it never once holds one up as the model to follow.**

For Reflection

- Which of these households do you think suffered the most, and why?
- Why would Scripture record these stories in so much detail?

SECTION V

The Hard Verses

Two passages are often used to argue that YHWH approved of polygamy. Both deserve a straight answer.

2 Samuel 12:8

I gave you your master's house, and your master's wives into your bosom, and gave you the house of Israel and of Judah; and if that would have been too little, I would have added to you many more such things.

2 SAMUEL 12:8

Read the context. Nathan has just told David a parable about a rich man with many flocks and a poor man who had nothing but "one little ewe lamb" (2 Samuel 12:3). In that culture a new king inherited the royal household of the old one, and YHWH is reminding David that He gave him everything: the throne, the house, the kingdom. David still stole a man's only wife. Then comes the sentence:

Now therefore the sword will never depart from your house, because you have despised me, and have taken Uriah the Hittite's wife to be your wife.

2 SAMUEL 12:10

This verse shows YHWH working through the customs of that day to rebuke David. It is a charge of ingratitude, not a blessing on a harem, and it never rewrites Genesis 2. Within a few chapters, the judgment in verse 11 was carried out on the roof of David's own house (2 Samuel 16:22).

Ezekiel 23 and Jeremiah 3

In these chapters YHWH describes Himself as husband to two sisters, Oholah and Oholibah, Samaria and Jerusalem, the house of Israel and the house of Judah. But those two were one people, one nation, torn in two by sin after Solomon (1 Kings 12). The split was the tragedy, not the design. And YHWH's promise is to put it back together:

I will make them one nation in the land, on the mountains of Israel. One king will be king to them all. They will no longer be two nations. They won't be divided into two kingdoms any more at all.

EZEKIEL 37:22

Even here, His plan ends with one.

For Reflection

- Why is it important to read 2 Samuel 12:8 together with verses 3 and 10?
- How does Ezekiel 37 change the way you read Ezekiel 23?

SECTION VI

One Bridegroom, One Bride

But, because of sexual immoralities, let each man have his own wife, and let each woman have her own husband.

1 CORINTHIANS 7:2

Each man, his own wife. Each woman, her own husband. When Paul set the standard for leaders in the assembly, he wrote:

The overseer therefore must be without reproach, the husband of one wife, temperate, sensible, modest, hospitable, good at teaching;

1 TIMOTHY 3:2

In the Greek this is *mias gunaikos andra*, literally "a one woman man" (also Titus 1:6). Those leaders were the example the whole assembly was called to follow (1 Corinthians 11:1).

And here is why it matters so much. Paul quotes Genesis 2:24 and then tells us what it has been pointing to all along:

For this cause a man will leave his father and mother, and will be joined to his wife. The two will become one flesh. This mystery is great, but I speak concerning Messiah and of the assembly.

EPHESIANS 5:31-32

Marriage is a living picture of Yahshua and His people. He does not have a collection of brides:

For the wedding of the Lamb has come, and his wife has made herself ready.

REVELATION 19:7

KEY POINT

One Bridegroom. One bride. Every marriage is meant to preach that message, from the garden to the wedding of the Lamb.

For Reflection

- What does your marriage, or the marriage you hope for, preach about Yahshua and His bride?

SECTION VII

Walking It Out

Few people reading this are weighing a second wife. But the same pull shows up in other forms: a divided heart, an emotional affair, a marriage where someone else holds the place that belongs to a spouse.

- **If you are married:** guard the "one." Let no one else, in person or on a screen, hold a place in your heart that belongs to your spouse. Cling, *dabaq*, to one.
- **If you come from a divided house:** the rivalry you grew up in is not your inheritance. Forgive, and ask Yahshua to heal what the division did to you. Joseph's story ended in reconciliation (Genesis 45:4-15).
- **If someone uses the patriarchs to justify it:** point them back to "the beginning," to Hannah's tears, to Solomon's turned heart, and to the one bride Yahshua is coming for.

SECTION VIII

Cross Reference Index

The design: Genesis 2:18-24; Genesis 7:13; Malachi 2:14-15; Matthew 19:4-6; Mark 10:6-9

Regulated, not designed: Matthew 19:8; Exodus 21:10; Deuteronomy 21:15-17

Limits: Leviticus 18:18; Deuteronomy 17:17

The rival wife: 1 Samuel 1:2-7

The households: Genesis 4:19-23; 16:1-6; 21:9-10; 26:34-35; 29-30; 37; Judges 8:30-9:5; 2 Samuel 3:2-5; 13; 15; 16:22; 1 Kings 1; 11:1-11

Named without a story: 1 Chronicles 2:18-19, 46-48; 1 Chronicles 4:5

The hard verses: 2 Samuel 12:1-11; Ezekiel 23; Jeremiah 3:6-10; Ezekiel 37:15-22

One bride: 1 Corinthians 7:2-4; 1 Timothy 3:2; Titus 1:6; Ephesians 5:22-33; Revelation 19:7-9

PUTTING IT INTO PRAYER

Yahshua, You are the Bridegroom, and You are coming for one bride. Thank You that Your design has never changed. Make my heart undivided toward You. Guard my marriage, or the marriage You have for me, and teach me to cling to one. Heal every place where division and rivalry wounded my family, and make us one again, the way You promised to make Your people one. Amen.

Personal Notes and Convictions

Restoring YHWH's design for marriage, family, forgiveness, and deliverance.